# Intent Before Method

Interrogate the Brief · Read what is actually being asked.

## The wall line

> *What had to be true before we could start? And why was it?*

**Context:** After the protected Reflection, name one condition you relied on before the work began and state whether today's work established it.

## Intent · link 1

**What are we solving for, and whose goal is it?**

Intent statement stem

**We are solving for _____, in service of _____'s goal.**

DS Smith: We are solving for faster development and connected business decisions, in service of the decision-makers' goal.

### Confidentiality

Your brief stays inside your assigned team. It is not projected or exchanged. Only your written Intent statement crosses the room.

# Three rounds · prompts and outputs

| Round | Min | Mode | Prompt | Output |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **1 · Read Your Brief** | 20 | individual → pairs inside the team · devices away | Read only your team's printed brief. Mark what is explicitly asked and what the brief treats as already true. | Each student's own marked-up copy |
| **2 · Interrogate It** | 20 | team · devices away | Build one three-column wall: Facts · Assumptions · What we would have to check. | One three-column wall |
| **3 · Write the Intent** | 20 | team → silent individual → room · devices away | Write one Intent statement, capture an individual position, then share only the prepared statement and one assumption. | One Intent card, read aloud |

## Round 3 · protected segments

### 10 min · Team · Write the Intent

team

### 4 min · Silent · Capture your position

silent individual

### 6 min · Room · Share the Intent

room

## Round 3 · private individual write

1. What did we decide?
2. What did we decide against?
3. What would have changed my mind?

# Bring to S03

1. Write three questions you would ask your client that the brief cannot currently answer.
2. For one question, state what answer would change your team's Intent statement.
3. Team captain to send the team name and the whole team's student IDs to michael-cm.tam@polyu.edu.hk.

# Reflection

15 min · handwritten A5 · record it for later upload to Logbook

1. What do I think differently now than I did at 09:30?
2. What did I do or say today that I would do differently?
3. What can I still not answer?

**Then:** one line, signed, for the wall.

# Glossary

| | |
|---|---|
| NPS | Net Promoter Score. |
| LQE | Legendary Quality Experience, a luxury-hospitality brand standard. |
| Cost to serve | The total cost of delivering and supporting an experience. |
| Proxy stakeholder | A person who represents another party's perspective when direct access is not available. |
| MagSafe | Apple's magnetic attachment system for compatible phone accessories. |
| Relationship Manager | A bank contact who supports a customer's financial relationship and product decisions. |

**THIS COPY CONTAINS YOUR TEAM'S ASSIGNED BRIEF.**

Keep it at your table. Do not project it or circulate it to another team.

PRIVATE TEAM BRIEF

# Mandarin Oriental

## THE PROBLEM SPACE (IN PLAIN LANGUAGE)

The pre-arrival experience in luxury hospitality is about trust, recognising guests' unique needs, and caring for them — while balancing the load this puts on internal operations. Once Mandarin Oriental asks a guest about their preferences, it has to deliver on them: failing to meet an expectation it set scores a negative Net Promoter Score (NPS), meeting it scores zero, and exceeding it scores positive.

The difficulty is that operational complexity multiplies fast. Three simple preference questions already produce more than twenty-seven permutations to manage across fifty or more daily arrivals, on top of room switching, reservation changes, and cost-to-serve limits. A previous attempt at hyper-personalisation was pushed too far and had to be halted for exactly this reason.

The core tension is how Mandarin Oriental builds engagement and manages guest expectations without over-promising — turning the brand's positioning as the “allure of eastern mastery” into a pre-arrival flywheel that builds anticipation, meets or delights on arrival, and drives loyalty and spend on property.

## WHY IT MATTERS COMMERCIALLY (ONE LINE)

It happens after booking, so it does not affect conversion — the impact is on brand equity and loyalty, and on how much guests spend while on property.

## WHAT YOU HAVE ALREADY TRIED (ONE LINE)

A hyper-personalisation pilot was pushed too far by previous leadership and halted for its operational complexity; Kate has last year's deck explaining why.

## HOW MIGHT WE...

How might we help Mandarin Oriental build guest engagement and manage expectations before arrival, without over-promising on what operations can actually deliver?

## STAKEHOLDERS — EXTERNAL

Guests, from pre-arrival through check-in — the audience every question in this brief is really about.

## STAKEHOLDERS — INTERNAL

Kate is acting as proxy stakeholder for this brief. The original project ran under the radar, so there is no need to involve other internal stakeholders at this stage.

## DATA THAT ALREADY EXISTS

Brand materials, which Kate will share for students to use.

NPS data — Kate is sourcing non-confidential figures to share.

The LQE (Legendary Quality Experience) standards: Mandarin Oriental's own brand standards, built on the Forbes Five Star minimums.

Three operational constraints, based on experience rather than data: turnover volume and efficiency, cost to serve, and flexibility at check-in.

A deck from last year explaining why the previous project was stopped, which Kate will share as context for what has already been tried.

OPTIONAL SELF-PRACTICE APPENDIX

This fictional brief is not used in today's slides or studio.

FICTIONAL · ILLUSTRATIVE ONLY

# Baseline Studios

### THE PROBLEM SPACE (IN PLAIN LANGUAGE)

New members join Baseline Studios after a goal-setting conversation at signup — what they want from training, how often they can realistically come, any injuries or limits. That conversation shapes the personalised programme a trainer builds for their first six weeks. The difficulty is that trainers already run near-full class and one-to-one schedules, so a programme promised at signup has to fit inside capacity that was fixed before the member ever walked in. When it doesn't fit, either the programme gets watered down without telling the member, or a trainer absorbs the extra load unpaid and starts resenting new members. Both outcomes look the same from the front desk: a member who quietly stops coming back within eight weeks.

### WHY IT MATTERS COMMERCIALLY (ONE LINE)

Early churn costs more than it looks like on paper — a member who leaves inside the first two months rarely renews, and studios already spend more acquiring a member than the first two months of fees recover.

### WHAT YOU HAVE ALREADY TRIED (ONE LINE)

A shorter, five-minute intake quiz replaced the old twenty-minute consultation to speed up signup; early churn hasn't moved.

### HOW MIGHT WE...

How might we set a new member's expectations at signup in a way Baseline's existing trainer capacity can actually keep, without making the first conversation feel like a sales pitch?

### STAKEHOLDERS — EXTERNAL

New members, from the day they sign up through their first eight weeks — the people every promise in this brief is actually about.

### STAKEHOLDERS — INTERNAL

Trainers build and deliver the programme. The front-desk team runs the signup quiz and is the one who actually hears from a member who feels let down — though nobody currently asks the front desk what they're hearing.

### DATA THAT ALREADY EXISTS

Signup quiz responses for the last twelve months. Trainer class and one-to-one schedules, booked at capacity most weeks. Membership records showing which members lapse inside eight weeks. No record of what front-desk staff hear from lapsing members — nobody has been asked.